Of war and peace

Why we need to go beyond the history of war and conflict in our educational institutions

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Mini Krishnan

Winning is so deeply embedded in our psyche that history is generally considered a chronicle of power; a list of who crushed whom and descriptions of rivalries amongst the strong.

Focus on conflict

The destruction of Troy in 1193 BCE, Alexander's defeat of Raja Purushothaman in 326 BCE, the Norman conquest of England in 1066, the fall of Constantinople in 1453, and the First Battle of Panipat in 1556. The siege of ... the war of ... the sacking of ... After all the fiery wars came the Cold War.

The history of war and conflict is a focus on the political trends and divisive forces of the world and has traditionally been a part of the political agenda of education. "Students need to know the history of their nation," is the foundation of this study programme. They do, they do. But is that all?

For a long time, it was uppermost in peoples' minds because hand-to-hand skirmishes and field battles between countries and adjacent regions were continuous, with the lives of whole populations under threat all the time.

Today, proxy wars are fought and, for reasons of national face-keeping or hand-washing, we continue to live with huge and unjust invasions of fellow humans that are far away enough to not disturb our day-to-day lives.

Poor second

My concern is: why does the intellectual history of mankind come a poor second to the history of bloody struggles between countries and civilisations? The calendar of man's artistic and technological ascent should be given more importance than it is. Given the academic atmosphere of classrooms, it could surely be both interesting and relevant.

Look at just one example in the history of ideas: When Islam and Christianity were locked in a fight to the death for the control of the Holy land, a community of European monks and scholars were in peaceful contact with their more advanced colleagues: scholars who were producing works of science and technology through translations into and out of Arabic in the great knowledge centres and libraries of Baghdad. There are many such instances.

Can we not also bring the untold his-and-her stories of the "daily"ness of the human experience into classrooms? What were peoples' lives like away from the sites of war? For instance, given the recent spread of interest in global cuisine, the history of food and habitats would be fascinating. Surely a good way to expand geography classes? Climate, vegetation, food habits, and food history.

Missing element

The missing element in social awareness of the nature of the human experience in History is a vital image of the day-to-day measures of life. The very language of teaching and the importance teachers give to research and human ingenuity would go a long way in shifting the schoolgoer's mind away from the nervous excitement that conflict generates.

What history and whose story? Telling students stories other than war stories would be a step towards their holistic development. Children raised with some emphasis on the positive side of human evolution would be less likely to develop prejudices about 'foreigners' or hostility towards people of different beliefs and social practices.

No amount of academic achievement can make up for the lack of emotional and life skills. What if one of our students grew up to be a brilliant scientist whose children are terrified of her? Is that the successful human being we want to raise? The greatest life skill is learning to understand that other people are as important as yourself and developing an empathetic attitude to all life.

Start early

This training can begin at an early age: caring for people around you. It is the lack of this value that leads to all the misunderstandings, fears, and even hatred of anyone who is not like oneself. In fact we have been watching with agony and alarm at what is happening in West Asia where one group of people think nothing of taking away the rights and lives of another.

Without value education, without peace education, our institutions are perfect training grounds for war because they place such a premium on success for the self and the self alone.

At least a part of History in classrooms should be an account of our humanity and our children should receive the universal message from the Mundaka Upanishad: "Like a thousand sparks from a blazing fire are we..." of the same nature, the same origin. Let's give the history of peace a place in our institutions.

The writer consults for the Tamil Nadu Textbook and Educational Services Corporation (TNTB & ESC).

SCHOLARSHIPS

NIDM Internship Programme
Offered by the National Institute of Disaster Management (NIDM)
Eligibility: Final-year UG and PG students, M.Phil, Ph.D. scholars, and recent graduates from Disaster Management and related fields such as Development Studies, Social Sciences, Environmental Science, Engineering, Health Studies, Architecture, Media, and Policy.
Rewards: Up to ₹15,000 a month.
Application: Online
Deadline: April 15
www.b4s.in/edge/NIDM1

University of Birmingham India Chancellor's Scholarships
Offered by the University of Birmingham the U.K.
Eligibility: Domiciled students of India who have received an offer for a full-time PG programme at the U.K. campus for September 2026 and are classified as an overseas fee payer for tuition purposes, and have the means to pay any outstanding tuition fees not covered by the scholarship.
Rewards: £10,000 towards tuition fees.
Application: Online
Deadline: May 31
www.b4s.in/edge/UCBD2

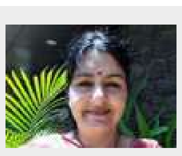
University of Strathclyde International Postgraduate Dean's Excellence Scholarship
Offered by the University of Strathclyde, Glasgow, the U.K.
Eligibility: International students pursuing a full-time postgraduate taught Master's programme within the Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences in a specified subject area and hold an offer to pursue a full-time course commencing in September.
Rewards: £10,000 for one year
Application: Online
Deadline: August 31
www.b4s.in/edge/USPI1

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Initiative

ideaForge Technology has launched the Who Are the Next Idiots? initiative in collaboration with IIT-Bombay. The six-month programme invites UG and PG students and recent graduates to participate individually or in teams of up to 4 members and submit original deep-tech ideas in domains such as robotics, energy systems, advanced materials, and autonomous technologies.

Deadline is April 30. https://tinyurl.com/2p9jjfdb



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

Consistency matters

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

I am a first-year Law student preparing for the UPSC. I am clueless about the study material. How do I crack the exam? K. Elamaran

Dear Elamaran,

THE UPSC CSE exam has three stages: Prelims, Mains and Interview. The Prelims have two papers. General Studies I focuses on History, Polity, Geography, Economy, Environment, Science and Tech, and Current Affairs. The General Studies II, also called CSAT, is a test of comprehension, logical reasoning, basic numeracy and general problem solving. Both papers are MCQ types.

The Mains have nine written papers of which the two language papers are qualifying ones. The others are an essay, four General Studies papers, and two papers on an optional subject.

Finally comes the interview, which assesses your personality, clarity of thought and understanding of current affairs.

Start with the NCERT History, Geography, Economics and Science (Classes 6-12) textbooks for the Prelims. Read newspapers every day to stay updated with current affairs. Look up books such as *Indian Polity* by M. Laxmikanth or *Indian Economy* by Ramesh Singh. For the CSAT, practise past papers to work on the skills required. If you choose Law as your optional subject for the Mains, your coursework will overlap with core topics such as constitution, governance, and judiciary, international relations or public administration. Start small, focus on consistent work on a daily and weekly plan. Practise essay writing, answering MCQs, revise current affairs, and make short notes for revision.

My son is in Class 12 (Accountancy with Computer Science). He wants a career in software development, data science, or systems analysis. How can he do this with his current non-Science stream in Class 12? Is there some way to bridge the gap? Naveen

Dear Naveen,

While a non-Maths Class 12 background does not permanently block a career in software, data science, or systems analysis, it is a challenge in our given academic system.

Most B. Tech programmes Maths require Maths in Class 12. He can consider BCA with a focus on Programming, database management, web development, and software engineering.

Colleges to consider are Christ University, Bengaluru; Loyola College, Chennai; and Amity University, Noida. Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT) offers B.Tech with bridge courses. Some private universities have foundation semesters in Maths and programming.

Look for five-year Integrated programmes (B.Sc + M.Sc / BCA + MBA / B.Tech + Data Science) that may allow non-Maths students if they complete foundation courses in Maths.

Online courses and certifications on NPTEL (Discrete Mathematics, Probability and Statistics), Khan Academy (Pre-Algebra, Algebra, Probability and Statistics), Coursera/ edX (Foundations for Data Science, Python and Maths, Programming and Logic, Python, C, or C++) can help bridge the gap. He can also practise algorithmic thinking via CodeChef, HackerRank, or LeetCode.

I cleared my CA Foundation and have been a sales consultant, a tutor at a coaching centre, a clerk in a bank, and an academic counsellor in an edtech company. Now I am preparing for NET-JRF, but have fallen out of the habit of studying. How can I improve my concentration? Samiksha

Dear Samiksha,

Why do you want a NET-JRF career? Are you opting for teaching and research because of job security, or job satisfaction? Create a vision board of what you want for yourself and keep it on your study table. Awareness is the first step to rebuilding focus. Work on resetting your study mindset.

Start small and build momentum, one day at a time. Use structured study techniques and focus on single tasks. Avoid multi-tasking while studying (no phone, social media scrolling or doing anything else).

Get enough sleep and a nutritious diet, exercise and some form of self-care.

Track your progress visually on a wall calendar to motivate yourself. Have a friend or an online study group so that you are held accountable for your progress.

Give yourself small rewards for completing a session well and look after your mental health.

I finished Class 12 last year and took a gap year to prepare for the NEET. But now I want to move to Finance. I didn't have Commerce as a subject in school. How do I make the move? Sarthak

You can move into finance without a Commerce background. Many professionals come from Science, Arts, or Engineering, and your background can actually be an advantage, especially for analytics, logical reasoning, and quantitative work.

You can explore areas like Corporate Finance, Banking, Investments, Financial Planning, Risk Management, Financial Modelling, or Fintech. To get started, build a foundation in accounting (balance sheets, P&L, cash flow), financial management (time value of money, ratios), basic economics, and corporate finance concepts. Alongside this, develop skills in Excel and financial modelling.

Use online platforms like Coursera, Udemy, NPTEL, and Investopedia, along with beginner-friendly finance books and YouTube channels, to strengthen your basics. For formal pathways, consider a BBA or B.Com (as a second degree or via lateral entry), or short-term certifications like CFA Level 1, Diploma in Banking and Finance, or Financial Modelling courses.

At the same time, focus on practical exposure through internships, projects like stock analysis, and skills in analytics (Python/SQL), Excel, and communication. Banking exams like SBI PO or IBPS PO are also strong entry routes.

With the right skills and consistent effort, transitioning into finance is very achievable.

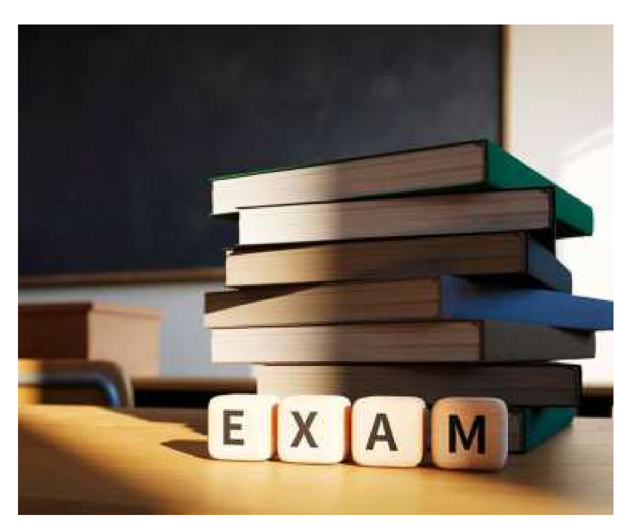
Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

From paper leaks to policy reform

Why we need to rebuild trust in India's exam systems

Karthick Sridhar



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India is often described as the world's largest democracy. Less frequently acknowledged is another reality: it is also the world's largest examination republic. Every year, around six crore students and job aspirants appear for high-stakes examinations across the country ranging from board exams in schools and entrance tests for university admissions to recruitment examinations for various government services.

In a nation where upward mobility is closely tied to educational and employment opportunities, the examination system functions as a powerful instrument of social justice. For millions of families, a single examination can determine the trajectory of a lifetime. This is why the integrity of the exam ecosystem is not merely an administrative concern but a matter of national trust.

India's examination ecosystem is massive in both size and impact: over three crore students appear for Class 10 and 12 board examinations each year; more than 25 lakh aspirants sit for the Joint Entrance Examination annually; the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test sees over 23 lakh candidates in a single cycle; and recruitment examinations conducted by agencies such as SSC, RRBs, and various state commissions collectively involve crores of applicants each year. Any breach in such a system is not an isolated administrative failure but a national disruption of trust.

Deeper damage

When a paper leak or impersonation racket is exposed, the immediate reaction is outrage. But the real damage is deeper and often lasts longer. First is the psychological impact on honest students. A candidate who has prepared for two or three years for a competitive examination suddenly begins to question the system itself. Effort appears uncertain, while shortcuts seem to be rewarded.

Second is the financial and social burden. Many aspirants spend significant sums on coaching, relocate to examination hubs, and delay employment opportunities in pursuit of success. A cancelled or compromised examination is not just an inconvenience. It is an economic and emotional setback.

Third is the long-term impact on professional quality. If entry-level examinations are compromised, the ripple effects become visible years later in the form of under-qualified professionals entering sensitive sectors, decline in service standards, and increased governance risks.

No country can aspire for global leadership if its talent pipeline is weakened at the point of entry. India's exam ecosystem today faces a growing trust deficit. The problem is not only the occurrence of malpractice, but also the perception that the system may be vulnerable. In the age of instant communication, rumours often travel faster than official clarifications. Even unverified claims can create panic among millions of candidates.

This perception gap has three consequences: Erosion of institutional credibility; rise of litigation and administrative delays; and normalisation of cynicism among youth. A country where young citizens begin to lose faith in meritocracy risks weakening its own developmental foundations.

Enter technology

Over the past decade, significant AI-led technological safeguards such as computer-based testing platforms, biometric authentication, encrypted digital question paper delivery, and enhanced identity verification mechanisms have been introduced into the examination process. While these have reduced certain types of malpractice, especially impersonation and large-scale copying, technology alone cannot eliminate cheating. Every secure system eventually faces attempts at breach. Fraud evolves, and systems must evolve faster.

Therefore, exam integrity must rest on three interlinked pillars: Technology to reduce vulnerabilities; governance to ensure accountability; and ethics to build a culture that respects merit. Without the third pillar, the first two will always remain incomplete.

What needs to be done

India's response to examination irregularities has often followed a familiar pattern of public outrage, investigation, cancellation or re-examination, and a temporary tightening of processes. But what is required is a comprehensive policy architecture for examination integrity. Periodic system audits, standardised protocols for high-stakes examinations, swift and transparent investigations, and stronger coordination between examination agencies are essential components of such an approach. Equally important is the need to ensure that innocent candidates are not subjected to avoidable hardship due to systemic failures. Justice in such matters must be both swift and fair.

No examination system in the world is completely immune to malpractice. The real measure of a system is not whether breaches occur, but how effectively and transparently it responds. India's exam ecosystem must evolve continuously through periodic review of processes, upgradation of technology, strengthening of governance frameworks, and promotion of ethical conduct across stakeholders.

Paper leaks are not merely administrative lapses. They are signals that systems must be strengthened, not merely repaired. The journey from paper leaks to policy reforms is, therefore, not just about fixing examinations. It is about rebuilding trust among students, parents, institutions, and the nation at large.

The writer is the Vice-Chairman of the Indian Centre for Academic Rankings and Excellence (ICARE)

Anushika Jain

Degrees of readiness

Why we need to integrate career exploration before the final year


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In a few months, final year students across India will be entering the workforce. Some will do so with confirmed offers, while others will still be waiting as placement drives unfold across campuses. For universities, this period is a routine. However, for students, it is decisive.

Rethink required

Placement season has become the most visible bridge between higher education and employment. It is also where career exploration often peaks and internship support expands. The system activates completely in the final year. Such a sequencing, however, deserves rethinking.

Most institutions align structured career engagement with measurable outcomes. Placement statistics feed accreditation documentation, ranking disclosures, and governing body reviews. A concentrated recruitment window produces clean data regarding offers secured, companies onboarded, and salaries reported.

Administratively, the model works but, for a student, it compresses decision making. Towards the end of the year, options in the academic pathways are largely fixed. Around the time when students encounter industry expectations shaped by applied experience and problem-solving capacity, the time available to recalibrate is limited.

Employers have moved toward evidence-based hiring. Candidates are now assessed on execution, not only comprehension. When structured industry engagement begins late, students face evaluation before their exploration stage has matured.

Many accept roles within the placement cycle because that is the available window. Subsequent early career shifts often reflect delayed discovery rather than professional growth. Attrition within the first years of employment is not only an organisational issue; it signals earlier misalignment.

This is not an argument against placements. Employment outcomes remain central to institutional accountability and to family expectations. The question is whether career discovery should be concentrated in the final year.

Undergraduate education spans three or four years. Exposure to professional pathways can, and should, mirror that duration. In the first year, structured orientation can introduce sector awareness through alumni interactions, short observational assignments, and reflective coursework linked to industry contexts. The objective is familiarity, not premature specialisation.

The second year can integrate credit-bearing internships and projects embedded within core subjects. Students can test their interest against lived experience and encounter constraints, deadlines, and collaborative work environments, while academic flexibility still exists.

By the third year, industry-linked assignments and sustained mentorship networks can deepen accountability. Portfolios take shape, skills are demonstrated, not assumed.

When the final year begins, placement preparation becomes a consolidation of these assessments, rather than a first exposure.

More pressure

Concentrating professional engagement at the end aligns neatly with reporting cycles. It does not align with the way judgment develops. Exposure requires time, and reflection requires space. Similarly, iteration requires repetition. Compressing these into a single academic year amplifies pressure.

There is also an equity dimension. Students with established professional networks often receive informal guidance long before campus systems activate.

First-generation learners depend more heavily on institutional design.

Concerns about academic dilution are often raised when professional engagement is introduced earlier. The premise assumes that intellectual depth and applied experience compete.

In practice, customised industry-linked coursework can strengthen theoretical understanding. Concepts tested in real contexts demand precision, and students adapt to learn by doing.

Universities have historically adapted their structures when external conditions changed. The labor market has changed. Hiring cycles are less predictable. Skill expectations evolve faster than curriculum committees typically convene. Sequencing career engagement across the undergraduate journey is a structural response to that shift.

However, final-year anxiety will not disappear because transition carries uncertainty. When exploration precedes evaluation, pressure distributes more evenly. The last year then focuses on the refinement of direction, not the creation of it.

Career readiness is cumulative. It is built across semesters, through structured exposure and deliberate reflection. The placement season should reflect that preparation, not substitute for it.

The writer is Founder and CEO, Globally Recruit.

Hear the answers

Raman and Lakshmanan, founders of Backyard Creators, on their domain

FUTURE PERFECT

Ananya Ganapathy

The next in the series featuring conversations with entrepreneurs, technologists, and researchers about emerging technologies and what students need to know about these fields.

What do you do?

Backyard Creators is a deep-tech company that works on restoring hearing through a non-invasive bionic ear for children with profound and severe hearing loss. Such children can only hear through implants. Our goal is to enable hearing externally by a dynamic magnetic field, without invasive procedures.

Why is your work important globally?

Our work focuses on achieving micro-scale neural stimulation externally by a dynamic magnetic field. Globally, 49 million people suffer from severe hearing loss and an estimated 100,000 children are born every year with hearing loss. But only a small percentage receive treatment due to various barriers. Beyond hearing, this approach could open pathways in diagnostics and other areas, making its impact far-reaching.

What is exciting about your work?

The most exciting part is that the answers do not exist yet. Our external sound processor uses advanced speech coding algorithms to analyse incoming sounds in real-time. Instead of using current pulses, it drives a precisely controlled dynamic magnetic field that interacts with the inner ear. This field targets specific cochlear regions corresponding to frequency bands, just like natural hearing. Creating new knowledge through hands-on experimentation, rather than applying known solutions, is what keeps us deeply motivated and curious.

Any experiences in college that led you to become an entrepreneur?

During school and college, we constantly worked on tinkering projects, science exhibitions, and small experiments. Over time, we realised that, to pursue our ideas seriously, we needed a legal structure to obtain grants. This led to our startup. The COVID period played a major role; with fewer exams and no classes, we had uninterrupted time to experiment, build, and discover what we truly wanted to work on.

What should students specifically know about applying AI to healthcare?

Any field demands strong expertise and foundations in fundamentals, whether Physics, Chemistry, Maths, Biology, Engineering or a combination. Students should focus on understanding the basics before choosing domains and build a deep understanding of the problems they are pursuing. It is also equally important to find the right teacher or mentor. We have learnt that, when you share your thinking honestly, the right people gradually find their way to you.

The writer is an avid follower of emerging technologies and their applications.

Shantanu Gangal

Where AI meets the real world

What a career in Forward-Deployed Engineering entails


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As Artificial Intelligence reshapes the technology landscape, new professional roles that didn't exist five years ago are emerging. Among these, Forward-Deployed Engineering (FDE) stands out as a unique opportunity for students entering the job market in 2026.

What is FDE?

The term 'forward deployed' has military origins but was popularised in the tech world by Palantir around 15 years ago. A Forward-Deployed Engineer sits at the junction where futuristic research meets present-day reality. The role bridges powerful AI systems with the messy, nuanced context of real businesses and involves running live experiments that rapidly mature the product. AI may be capable, but it lacks the operational understanding organisations have built over the years. The FDE supplies that missing context and shapes how AI behaves in production.

This role has evolved faster than any course curriculum. It is learnt on the ground, by solving hard problems and developing an instinct for how to push the technology to its limits. In other words, a forward-deployed engineer is someone who can naturally communicate with AI in ways that dramatically improve its performance.

The forward-deployed aspect refers to the physical reality of the role. These engineers travel to and are stationed at client sites, spending weeks at manufacturing facilities, financial institutions, or healthcare providers, immersing themselves in operational contexts before configuring AI agents to work effectively in those environments.

What does the job actually involve?

Context Capture and Engineering: Spending time on-site to understand the client's business processes, challenges, and operational workflows, shadowing employees studying existing systems. This informs how the FDE architects the AI's operational environment: curating what data the agent sees, which tools it accesses, and how it interprets the client's reality. Prompting is one piece; the FDE must engineer the entire context in which the agent operates, establishing parameters that allow it to act effectively within highly specific business constraints.

Continuous Optimisation and Product Evolution: Leveraging each deployment as an experiment to validate product ideas and incorporate learnings back into the platform. As AI models evolve, FDEs redeploy new versions, rewrite prompts, and ensure continued performance. AI requires constant attention and refinement.

Translation and Communication: Acting as the interface between technical teams and business stakeholders, explaining AI capabilities and limitations in accessible terms while ensuring alignment between what's technically possible and what's operationally valuable.

Skills needed

Forward-deployed Engineering suits those who combine strong technical foundations with excellent communication skills and an interest in client-facing work. FDEs must own outcomes, take the initiative without direction, and navigate ambiguity with confidence while clearly explaining technical concepts to non-technical stakeholders.

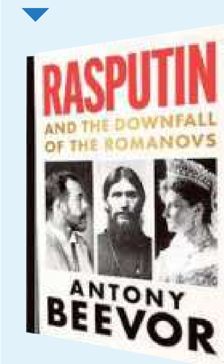
There is no single prescribed educational path for this domain. The role values interdisciplinary backgrounds spanning Computer Science, Engineering, Maths, Business, Economics, or domain-specific fields such as Healthcare or Finance. A finance graduate with skills in Python, APIs, and AI tools can be as effective as a Computer Science graduate who understands organisational workflows.

Beyond formal degrees, aspiring forward-deployed engineers should build capabilities in AI and machine learning fundamentals, prompt engineering and large language models, data analytics and visualisation, and strong programming skills, particularly in Python. These technical skills must be complemented by logical reasoning, creative problem-solving, comfort with ambiguity, and the ability to clearly communicate complex AI concepts through documentation and cross-functional collaboration.

Crucially, this is not a career that demands years of specialised preparation. Students with the right skills, curiosity, and learning agility can begin preparing for these roles while still in college.

The writer is the co-founder and CEO of Prodigal

ON THE SHELF



Rasputin and the Downfall of the Romanovs

How could a barely literate peasant from Siberia determine the fate of the world? Undoubtedly, the so-called 'mad monk' Rasputin bewitched Tsar Nicholas II and his wife, Alexandra. Yet their strange and scandalous relationship conceals a riddle. Rasputin was a devoted monarchist, not a revolutionary. He had no official position, no forces at his command but contributed more to the fall of the Romanov dynasty than any other individual.

Just as Rasputin cast a spell over the Romanovs, his legend has bewitched historians. More than a century later, we still fail to comprehend fully the collapse of the greatest autocracy on Earth. Was there any truth to the wild tales that brought down the empire? Or was his true legacy an unsettling lesson on the potency of myth? A new biography of one of history's disturbing and dubious masterminds.

Author: Antony Beevor
Publisher: Hachette
Price: ₹699

Courts of tomorrow

Reimagining legal education in the age of AI

Vishwas H. Devaiah
Simreen Bajwa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Artificial Intelligence (AI) is continuously engaging with and remodelling the legal profession, be it predictive analytics to assess litigation outcomes or AI-assisted contract review tools.

However, legal education in India continues to rely heavily on conventional doctrinal approaches and legal theory. While these foundations are important, today's lawyer also has to be able to collate vast amounts of data, research through extensive data bases, and, based on the analysis of these predictive AI tools, choose a course of action. Therefore, a law graduate must have a firm hold on the workings of these AI tools.

But introducing AI prematurely without adequate protection mechanisms risks amplifying the existing imbalances. For instance, many sophisticated AI tools lie behind costly subscriptions or paywalls and are inaccessible to the majority of public law school students. If integration is done without addressing these issues, the access divide between institutions and students can widen. Another issue is that over-reliance on AI tools could potentially undermine the development of core legal and analytical skills. The fundamental legal skills of logical reasoning, interpreting, and deducing cannot be outsourced to an algorithm. A study conducted by Rahul Hemrajani, Assistant Professor, NLSIU indicates that current LLMs can augment legal work but fall short of nuanced legal reasoning. Law schools must, therefore, introduce AI as a supplement rather than a one-stop solution.

Curricular reform

Wary does not mean unwilling. A start can be made by incorporating contemporary legal practices and training alongside theoretical legal instructions. Students can be steadily familiarised with the workings of these sophisticated tools, digital filing systems and AI-powered legal research engines. Progressive exposure will not only help demystify technology but also allow students to holistically understand its workings and limitations.

Courses on AI ethics, workings, accountability and compliance are equally important to address questions around bias, transparency and responsibility, veracity of AI-generated output. This will help equip students with the regulatory frameworks required to navigate the labyrinth of ethical, operational, and societal challenges.

Curricular reform should also prioritise critical thinking and courtroom strategy. Persuasion, ethical judgment, and contextual understanding cannot be automated. Practical training through simulations, drafting exercises, and supervised litigation clinics can help students learn how to deploy technology strategically without surrendering professional judgment.

Further to resolve access issues, educational institutions must adopt inclusive implementation strategies such as prioritising publicly available and institutionally licensed tools, building inclusive digital frameworks and ensuring that instructions related to AI tools and algorithms are rooted within the curriculum, rather than being contingent on individual students' paying capacity. Additionally, faculty training becomes crucial to guarantee that these reforms are implemented properly.

Incorporating AI into legal education involves balancing competing interests to safeguard equity without impacting innovation. Reform must be deliberate, inclusive, and grounded in pedagogical integrity.

Vishwas H. Devaiah is Acting Dean and Simreen Bajwa is Associate (Research and International Partnerships) at BITS Law School.